

THE OPENING SALVO

On average, in a T20 match, openers face 40 deliveries, **translating to one-third of the total balls** a team could face.

Pranay Rajiv & Mayank

pranay.rajiv@thehindu.co.in,
mayank.c@thehindu.co.in

Of the many factors that could determine a T20 team's fate, none is as prominent as the performance of its opening pair.

On average, in a T20 match, openers face 40 deliveries, translating to one-third of the total balls a team could face. The runs they score and the rate at which they do it are vital to the team's fortune in a tournament.

The situation is no different in the IPL. In the past 16 editions, **only one team (Mumbai Indians in 2013) has managed to win the title** without its opening pair aggregating 300+ runs in a season.

Teams have grown to recognise the need to place their best players up front, with Royal Challengers

Bangalore's promotion of Virat Kohli as an opener being the most significant example.

Here are the possible opening combinations for each IPL side going into the 17th edition of the tournament.

CSK

The success of the Ruturaj Gaikwad-Devon Conway combination was the cornerstone of Chennai Super Kings' title win last season. CSK, though, will be without Conway, at least for the first half of IPL 2024, due to a thumb injury. In

the newly acquired Rachin Ravindra, CSK has a nearly like-for-like replacement for Conway. In addition to being a left-hander, the 24-year-old Kiwi can also provide a few handy overs with his off-spin.

The experienced Ajinkya Rahane, who had an impressive first season with CSK, is a left-field option to partner Gaikwad up top.

RR

Rajasthan Royals is one of the few teams heading into the 2024 IPL season unworried about its opening pair. Yashasvi Jaiswal and Jos Buttler

